

Soft Where?

Answer the questions, why, what, where and how to buy software for your business

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Last month I took you through the process of buying hardware for a small office, but without the right software installed, all that hardware is useless. In this article, I will take you through the processes involved in buying software for a small office setup.

Piracy is rampant, and India is no exception—9 out of 10 people in India have pirated software installed on their machine. Worst, most of them are not even aware of this fact. With cyber laws in place, it would be prudent not to be on the wrong side of the law. That's not the only reason why one should buy genuine software though. Legal obligation aside, if you are using pirated software, critical updates and patches required to bolster security against viruses, worms and other malware are not made available to you, which leaves your entire computer network open—a situation which should be avoided at all costs, especially in a business environment.

Buying legal software also entitles you to technical help from the vendor. Initially, this might seem unimportant, but as your business grows and dependence on IT increases technical help becomes a critical factor. For example, you might want to customise the accounting software to your needs, or might want to merge two different databases, or want your old database made available on a newer version, in such situations vendors are your best bet and buying original software from them automatically gives you bargaining power.

Proprietary Or Open Source?

Once you have made up your mind to invest in software, the immediate question that arises is, "Should I opt for Free, Open Source software, or pay and buy proprietary software?" The answer to this question depends on the kind of infrastructure you want to put up, and whether you will have a resident technical person looking after it. Both Open Source and proprietary software have their distinct advantages, and hence a healthy mix of both should be used to maximise return on investments (ROI). In a client/server model, which will be used in most organisations, Open source can be deployed on the server side and Windows can (should) be used on the client side. Such an approach will return good ROI and on a technical level will offer a robust platform.

For an office with more than 10 computers it's better to have a technical administrator overseeing matters. If he is competent in Open Source Software (OSS) then deploying OSS might be an option. Even if you have a consulting Open Source Software expert, deploying OSS can be considered. The key in deploying OSS is the availability of technical competence.

Can't Linux be deployed on the desktop too? Technically, yes, there are many opportunities to deploy Linux on desktops. If you are running a technical firm, for example, software development, where there is no dearth of technical people, you can deploy Linux on the desktop. Also, if you're looking at a customer service and data entry department, where only data read/write happens from databases, Linux can be deployed. However, in the case of an Accounts department, the Marketing, creative department, etc., Linux on the desktop isn't recommended. People from such departments are generally accustomed to the Windows environment, and expecting them to unlearn it and learn Linux can be a serious challenge. In order to improve bottom-line and ROI, don't blindly push Linux as it might prove counter-productive.

First Things First

An operating systems (OS) is the first software you need to install on all machines. Microsoft's Windows is widely used and is very popular. Windows XP and Windows Vista are the two versions which you will come across most often, as they are pre-loaded by PC and laptop vendors. Windows is not the only OS available though, Mac OSX by Apple and various flavours of Linux are also available. In a business environment, you need two types of OSes; desktop or client OS and server OS. Windows XP and Windows Vista are client operating systems whereas Windows Server 2003 is a server operating system.

Before any software is purchased, pay close attention to its licensing policy. A license is nothing but terms and agreements related to the use of that particular software. Let's take some examples here to clear the mysteries surrounding Windows products. Microsoft's software can be bought in three ways namely, OEM, Buying online and Dial-a-software. Vendors such as Dell, Lenovo, Wipro, etc., offer pre-loaded operating systems with their PCs and laptops—these fall under the OEM bracket.